







Rajgir Beckons...

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> **Narayan Prasad**
> Bihar Tourism Minister

Rajgir, one of the world's most-acclaimed Buddhist pilgrimage centres in Bihar, makes us pause and contemplate the profound significance of the place where both Gautam Buddha and Mahavira once spent days meditating and preaching.

Rajgir was also the first capital city of the great Magadha kings until the 5th century BC when Udaiyin (460–440 BC), son of Ajatshatru, moved the capital to Patliputra. More than two thousand years later, Bihar Tourism is taking multiple initiatives to ensure that the historically significant city, located nearly 100 kms south-east of Patna, also emerges as a must-visit contemporary tourist destination.

Surrounded by seven hills with River Panchane flowing through the outskirts of the town, the picturesque Rajgir is barely 30 km from Nalanda. The lush green forest cover adds to its scenic beauty. Here two rock-cut caves were the favourite retreats of the Buddha and it was on this hill that he preached two of his most famous sermo-ns after attaining enlightenment.

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Rajgir has emerged as a promising destination, due to Bihar Tourism's strategic planning. As aptly told by Bihar Tourism Minister, "the idea is to provide compelling experiences, quality infrastructure, and remarkable services to the visitors."

The Highlights of Rajgir

Rajgir boasts of the spectacular 'Glass Sky Walk, 200 feet high and 85 feet long glass-bottomed modern tourist attraction; it also boasts one of the world's highest peace pagoda called Vishwa Shanti Stupa constructed atop the Ratnagiri Hill.

Along with the hustle-bustle of modern tourism, Rajgir is also a place that exudes peace and quiet. The hills are known for their scenic beauty and as a historical and religious centre for Hindus, Buddhists, and Jains.

Rajgir's most recent inclusion is a Nature Safari developed over 500-hectares of land with various recreational amenities like a suspension bridge, zip-lining, rock climbing wall, archery range, wrestling zone, watch tower and children's park.

"Rajgir tourism also abounds in monuments and places that can enrich the traveller's knowledge and experiences and can thrill anybody. The major attractions include Pandu Pokhar, Ghora Katora, Shanti Stupa, Venu Van, Ajatshatru Fort, Swarna Bhandar and various other famous tourist destinations," said the tourism Minister.

Rajgir also has a number of warm water ponds and springs, which are believed to contain some medicinal properties to help cure many skin diseases. No wonder, the Bihar tourism department wants to project Rajgir as a perfect winter tourism destination.

An eight-seat cabin car ropeway will offer tourists a more convenient and safe journey to the Vishwa Shanti Stupa, one of the tallest stupas in the country. It is close to where Lord Buddha preached for several years at the adjoining Gridhakuta hills and also a place visited by Lord Mahavira.

Why Rajgir is a must visit destination

There are myriad reasons to visit Rajgir and can be different for different people. It qualifies as a desirable destination for peace seekers, family travellers, adventure groups and spiritual tourists seeking to trace Sidhartha's journey from an angst-ridden prince and truth seeker to the enlightened Gautama Buddha. He addressed the sangha at the Gridhakuta, the hill of vultures, which inspired Mauryan king Bimbisara to adopt Buddhism.

According to Indian Tourism Statistics 2019 **prepared by Ministry of Tourism, Government of India, more than 3.24 crore domestic and 10.82 lakh foreign tourists visited Bihar in 2017 while in 2018, the number of domestic tourists increased to more than 3.36 crore and those of foreign tourists marginally to 10,87,971. Bihar ranks 14th in domestic tourist visits and 9th in terms of visits by foreign tourists. All the efforts of Bihar Tourism is only expected to grow this number in times to come.**

